

ACADEMIC ESSAY

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The City of Happiness

Aspiration, dignity, and the transformation of human expectation in one life

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Abstract

This paper takes the theme of "great expectations" — the projected desires a person holds for the future — and asks a philosophical question about their nature: are such expectations a fixed human appetite, or a capacity that is formed, narrowed, and transferred by the conditions of a life? Working from the testimony of a single interlocutor, Ramchandra Shil, a Hindu barber in Dhaka in his mid-fifties who survived the famine of 1974, it argues that expectation is not a constant but undergoes three characteristic transformations: from the self to one's children, from having to being, and from achievement to acceptance. It then confronts the hardest question his account raises. When a poor man scales down his wants and stakes everything on his children, is that wisdom or is it the quiet defeat that the philosophy of adaptive preference describes? The paper argues that it is genuinely both, and that the criterion for telling them apart is dignity: Shil's refusal of unearned money and his insistence that his children "become human" show an expectation that has not merely shrunk but reorganised around something worth wanting. It closes with the ethical caution that to admire the dignity of an adaptation must never become a way of excusing the conditions that demanded it.

1. The shape of a want

Charles Dickens gave the phrase its resonance: "great expectations" are the projected desires a person carries for a future not yet arrived, and the novel that bears the name is, in the end, a study of how those desires are shaped and deformed by wealth, class, and circumstance. Set as a theme for reflection, the phrase invites a philosophical rather than a literary question. Are the great expectations of a human life a fixed appetite — a natural hunger for more that every person carries in roughly the same measure — or are they a capacity, formed and reformed by the conditions under which a life is actually lived? If the latter, then expectation is not a constant against which we can measure fortune, but itself one of fortune's products, and the study of what people dare to want becomes a study of what has been done to them.

This paper pursues that question through a single account. Ramchandra Shil is a Hindu barber in Dhaka, in his mid-fifties, who grew up in the famine that followed Bangladesh's independence and who has spent his life at the edge of security. I take his testimony not as a sample from which to generalise but as a site for philosophical attention: one life, closely heard, can pose

questions that no aggregate can. The method has a constraint built into it by the terms of the exercise, and it is a fitting one. I attend to his account of his own expectations, not to the aspirations of the educated interviewers who elicited them, because the philosophical interest lies precisely in a horizon of wanting that the privileged rarely inhabit and too easily speak over.

His testimony, read closely, shows expectation undergoing three transformations. It migrates from the self to his children; it shifts from the language of having to the language of being; and it settles, with age and after failure, from the register of achievement into the register of acceptance. Tracing these three movements is the work of the middle of this paper. But they converge on a single hard question, and that question is the paper's real subject. When a man who has been defeated by circumstance narrows his wants and transfers his dream to the next generation, has he grown wise, or has he been quietly taught not to want what he was never going to be allowed to have? I will argue that both are present in Shil's account, that the philosophy of adaptive preference is right to make us suspicious, and that the mark by which his acceptance can be distinguished from mere resignation is dignity — visible above all in what he refuses.

2. The capacity to aspire

The most penetrating thing Shil says is also the most easily missed, and it is not about any particular want but about the conditions under which a want can be formed at all. Asked whether there was something he had always desired but never voiced, he answers that there were such things, "but I never found the right person to tell," and then, of his childhood: "who would I ask? There was no way to ask. I couldn't ask my father, and I couldn't ask my mother. We were just deprived of that." The deprivation he names is not, in the first instance, a deprivation of goods. It is a deprivation of the standing to want — of the social space in which a desire can be uttered, entertained, and directed toward a plausible future.

Arjun Appadurai (2004) gives this its concept. The "capacity to aspire," he argues, is a navigational capacity, unevenly distributed across a society: the affluent have many chances to practise it, to form aspirations, test them against outcomes, and revise the map of what is reachable, while the poor, whose horizon of plausible futures is thin and whose every projection is quickly disciplined by failure, have far fewer opportunities to exercise it. Aspiration, on this

view, is not a private spark equal in all breasts but a cultural competence that circumstance cultivates or starves. Shil's account is a textbook instance of the starved case. His childhood offered no addressee for a want and no path along which a want might travel; "we were just deprived of that" is the report of a capacity that was never allowed to develop, and it should correct the comfortable assumption that everyone begins with the same great expectations and merely meets different luck. Some are deprived of the expectations themselves.

The material substrate of that deprivation is not metaphorical. Shil grew up, he says, eating wild ghechu and shaluk roots gathered from neck-deep water during the famine that followed independence — the Bangladesh famine of 1974, the very catastrophe that Amartya Sen (1981) made the centre of his entitlement theory of famine, the argument that people starve not because food is absent but because they lose the entitlements that command it. The man reciting the roots he ate is a survivor of the case study. And Sen's later work draws the line from that entitlement failure directly to the theme of this paper. In the capability approach, what matters for a person's life is not the resources they hold but their real freedom to be and to do — their capabilities — and among these is the capacity to form and pursue a conception of the good (Sen, 1999). Poverty, on this account, is the deprivation of capability, and one of the capabilities it deprives is the capacity to aspire. Shil's history is the demonstration: the famine took the roots-eating child's freedom to want, long before it took anything he could name.

3. From having to being

When Shil is finally asked, directly, what he most wants, the answer does not name a possession. His "only wish," repeated across the conversation like a refrain, is to raise his children "to be proper human beings before I leave this world" — to "make them human." The Bengali ideal he is reaching for, of *manush howa*, becoming a real human being, names a moral accomplishment rather than a material one, and it sits at the centre of his expectations where a Western frame might expect to find a career or a fortune. His great expectation is an expectation about the kind of persons his children will be.

This is not a naïve indifference to material things, and the account is more philosophically precise than it first appears. Aristotle held that the human good, *eudaimonia*, is an activity of the soul in accordance with virtue, and that external goods — wealth, property, the house and the car

— are instruments, necessary up to a point as the equipment of a good life but never its substance; to mistake the instrument for the end is the characteristic error about happiness (Aristotle, 2009). Erich Fromm (1976) drew the same distinction as two modes of existence, the "having" mode that locates the self in what it possesses and the "being" mode that locates it in what it is and does. Shil's hierarchy is, in these terms, correctly ordered. Being comes first: the children must become human. Having is real but subordinate and, tellingly, wished for on their behalf rather than his own — a house and a car, "so they can live in peace and happiness." He does want the external goods; he simply does not confuse them with the end, and he assigns them to the next generation as the equipment their being will need.

The clearest evidence that his expectation is structured by virtue rather than mere want comes when the interviewer offers him, hypothetically, unlimited money. He refuses it. "The money I earn myself is what's right for me. The money someone else gives me is wrong... because if someone else gives me money and I spend it, that requires falling into greed." Here a man with almost nothing declines a fortune on principle, and the principle is philosophically substantial. It is, first, a commitment to autonomy in something close to Kant's sense: dignity attaches to the self-determining agent, and to live on money one has not earned is to make oneself heteronomous, dependent on another's will (Kant, 1998). It is, second, a refusal of pleonexia, the graspingness that Aristotle placed among the vices, and an insistence that a want pursued by the wrong means corrupts the want. What looks at first like an old man's stubbornness is in fact a claim about the internal connection between a good life and the manner of its getting: an expectation fulfilled by greed is not, for Shil, a fulfilment at all. His wanting has a shape, and the shape is ethical before it is material.

4. From self to progeny

The second transformation is the one the whole account performs before our eyes: the migration of expectation from the self to the children. Shil's dreams for himself are spoken in the past tense — "dreams weren't fulfilled, dreams failed" — while every dream in the present tense is a dream about his sons. The eldest has finished his honours and entered a master's; the middle is at his honours; the youngest is in class eight; and the father's remaining desire is exhausted by their advance: "that they move forward, so they can get a house and a car, and so they can live in peace and happiness."

Erik Erikson (1950) named the disposition at work here generativity: the mature adult's turn from self-advancement to care for the establishment of the next generation, which he set against its failure-mode of stagnation and self-absorption. On Erikson's account this is not a consolation prize for a thwarted life but a developmental achievement, the form the self's projects properly take once the self recognises its own finitude. Aristotle would locate the same movement in *philia* and in the natural love of parents for offspring, in which a person comes to count another's good as part of their own, so that the boundary of the self widens to enclose the child. Read through these lenses, Shil's transfer of his expectations is not the erasure of his wanting but its extension: the "I" that wanted to advance has become a "we," and the horizon of his hope now reaches past the horizon of his life.

That reach past his own life is the most moving, and philosophically the most exposed, feature of his hope. "If I have the luck, I'll get to see it, and if not, then I won't." He hopes for outcomes he may not live to witness, and he frames the whole in the vocabulary of blessing: "This is my blessing for them before I go." A hope that outruns the hoper's own existence is a peculiar object. It cannot be a self-interested expectation of future satisfaction, for the self may not be there to be satisfied; it is something closer to a gift, an act of provision whose good is entirely the recipient's. Whether such a hope is a triumph of love or a symptom of resignation — whether the transfer has widened the self or merely surrendered it — cannot be settled at the level of the transfer itself. It is settled, if at all, by the question the next section takes up.

5. From achievement to acceptance

The third transformation is the one that makes the account philosophically difficult. With age and after failure, Shil's expectations move out of the register of achievement and into the register of acceptance. "Life's happiness is over; we are at the final stage now. Now we just survive eating dal and rice, doing business." Of the house and car he once wanted for himself: "It's not in my destiny to have a house and a car... God didn't arrange that for me." The horizon has closed; what remains is to "move forward slowly, as much as I can, for the few days I have left."

There are two philosophical readings of this settling, and they point in opposite moral directions. The first is Stoic. Epictetus taught that the good life turns on a clear division between what is up to us and what is not, and on the discipline of desiring only the former, so that the wise person,

wanting nothing that fortune controls, is never at fortune's mercy (Epictetus, 2008). On this reading Shil has achieved something enviable: he has stopped breaking himself against a world he cannot command, aligned his wants with what is actually available, and found in that alignment the "peace" he names as his aim. His serenity is wisdom, the hard-won amor fati of a man who has made his peace with a life he did not choose.

The second reading is darker, and the philosophy of adaptive preference supplies it. Jon Elster (1983), in the parable of the fox and the sour grapes, described the mechanism by which people cease to want what they cannot have and then experience the ceasing as contentment; the preference adjusts to the possibility, and the adjustment conceals the deprivation. Martha Nussbaum (2000) turned this into a critique of any ethics that takes satisfied preferences as the measure of a good life, warning that the deprived learn not to desire what they have been denied, that this learned contentment renders their deprivation invisible, and that to read it as wisdom is to complete the injustice by absolving it. On this reading Shil's "it is not in my destiny," his attribution of his empty-handedness to God's arrangement, is exactly the voice of adapted preference: the world foreclosed his wants and taught him to call the foreclosure fate.

The crux of this paper is that we cannot dismiss either reading, and that the task is to find the criterion that distinguishes them, because the same outward calm can express wisdom or defeat. I want to propose that the criterion is this: adaptive preference is the shrinking of what one dares to want, the collapse of the wanting itself into the shape of the possible, whereas Stoic acceptance is the reconstitution of wanting around what remains genuinely worth pursuing. By that test, Shil's acceptance is closer to reconstitution than to collapse, and the evidence is precisely the material of the earlier sections. A man whose wants had merely shrunk to fit his circumstances would take the offered fortune; Shil refuses it, which shows that he still holds standards his circumstances do not dictate. A man merely resigned would have no live expectation left; Shil has a demanding one, the moral formation of his children, which is not a lowered version of his old dream of advancement but a different and arguably higher object. His wanting has not been extinguished and disguised as peace. It has been moved, and moralised, and pointed past his own death. That is not the fox deciding the grapes were sour. It is a man who has lost the grapes deciding what, in their absence, is still worth tending.

This does not dissolve the darker reading; it disciplines it. Some of Shil's fatalism surely is adaptive — the language of destiny doing the work that a juster world would have made unnecessary — and it would be a sentimental error to pretend otherwise. The honest conclusion is that his acceptance is a mixture, and that its dignified component does not cancel its adapted one. What it does establish is that his settling is not merely the defeat of expectation. It is expectation's survival of its own defeat, in a changed and narrowed and partly imposed but still recognisably chosen form.

6. Recognition, and the wants that were never said

One exchange stands slightly apart from the arc of expectation and yet completes the picture. Asked what has made him feel respected, or disrespected, in his life, Shil cannot produce an instance. "I have never experienced anything like that." Pressed for a single moment of feeling deeply respected, he answers, flatly, "No." The interviewer, whose own frame of reference includes a father made proud by a university admission, is asking from within a life where recognition is a familiar event; Shil answers from within a life where it is not part of the horizon at all.

Axel Honneth (1995) argues that a person's practical relation to self is built through recognition: self-respect in particular depends on being recognised, by others and by institutions, as a bearer of standing, and the denial of recognition is a distinct form of harm, a moral injury separate from material deprivation. Shil's inability to name a moment of respect is, in these terms, not a modest man declining to boast but the trace of a life largely outside the circuits through which recognition is distributed. And it connects back to the deprivation with which this paper began. To aspire aloud, one needs an addressee; to be recognised, one needs a public that confers standing; and the poor, Appadurai's argument implies, are short of both. The unspoken wants that "never found the right person to tell" and the absent moment of respect are the same deprivation seen twice: a life in which there was neither the standing to voice a great expectation nor the recognition that would have answered it.

7. The dignity of a diminished hope

Great expectations, this account suggests, are not a fixed human constant but a conditioned, temporal, and transferable capacity. They are conditioned, because the freedom to form and

voice a great expectation is a capability that material entitlement and social recognition confer or withhold, and Ramchandra Shil was, in his own exact word, "deprived" of it before he could name a single want. They are temporal, because they change register across a life, hardening from the open-ended dreams of advancement into the closed arithmetic of "the few days I have left." And they are transferable, because expectation can survive the defeat of the one who holds it by migrating into another, so that a father's failed dream of moving forward becomes his sons' honours degrees and his blessing at the door.

The philosophical lesson of his testimony is that the worth of an expectation is not measured by its magnitude. The educated dream of eminence is not, as such, nobler than the barber's dream that his children become human and live in peace; and Shil's refusal of unearned money is a more demanding ethical act than most large ambitions require. What distinguishes an expectation that has been merely beaten down from one that has been genuinely reconstituted is not its size but whether, under pressure, it reorganises around something still worth wanting. By that measure Shil did not simply lower his expectations. In losing the house, the car, the "city of happiness" he never reached, and in staking what remained on his children's becoming-human and refusing every shortcut that greed would have offered, he did something more exacting than lowering them. He purified them.

And yet the paper must end on the note that Nussbaum's warning demands, because the alternative is to turn a philosophical appreciation into a political anaesthetic. To admire the dignity with which Ramchandra Shil met his circumstances is right; to let that admiration console us for the circumstances is not. His serenity is an achievement, but it is an achievement wrung from a deprivation that a decent society would not have imposed — the famine, the lost schooling, the swindled savings, the standing to aspire that he never had. The dignity is his. The conditions that made such dignity necessary are ours to answer for. A life should not have to become this admirable in order to be borne, and the final expectation worth holding, reading his, is that fewer lives should have to.

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